

shoppers spent up to 100 per cent more when they paid using their credit card instead of cash.

But what does this all this research mean for our finances? While we might suspect that we are a self-controller or a non-self-controller by whether we identify as a spender or a saver, can we find a way to regulate our brain and our dopamine levels? Or do we need to reject technology and move to cash only? Do we just give up now and acknowledge that our genes are driving and controlling us and modern society is making it impossible for us to do anything about it?

The good news is, the sum results of these experiments show we can take heart knowing that once we understand the driver for our behaviour we can adapt our behaviour or environment to create more positive financial outcomes. How we do that isn't by rejecting modern technology and becoming a hermit, but rather by observing and recognising how we inherently financially behave and developing unique systems that financially benefit us.

The truth is some of the changes we can make will have an immediate effect, such as at times switching from digitised payments to cash. Or finding a dopamine kick from somewhere other than simply spending money. For example, it's possible for us to receive a dopamine hit from other places. That might include getting enough sunlight, meditating, listening to music, getting enough sleep, exercising regularly, consuming probiotics, eating less saturated fats, eating more protein and even having sex. This means that, sure, while nature can give some people a financial advantage by giving them an inbuilt rewards-based system, it's possible to create a similar environment or new pathways with the type of environment you create for yourself. It means you can artificially create an environment conducive to increased self-control.

While it's helpful to understand how we innately behave, most of us aren't travelling with a suite of researchers and scientists to help us discover our financial DNA. That's why I've developed the system that helps you identify how you are financially inclined to behave for yourself: your Financial Phenotype.

Understanding your Money Story and Money Environment is the first step in discovering your Financial Phenotype, while identifying your Money Type is the second step. Discovering your Money Type (and it could